

Polynesian expansion

From around 1500 BCE, the Lapita people—seafarers from Southeast Asia—started to explore the oceans. Traveling eastward, they settled Fiji and Samoa, and later Hawaii, New Zealand, and many more islands in the Pacific Ocean that are now known as Polynesia. Settlers on each island or group of islands developed their own unique culture over the centuries.

▼ THE MOAI

A row of large stone statues, called Moai, stand on Rapa Nui (Easter Island), facing inward toward land. Built between the 11th and 17th centuries, the 887 statues are believed to represent the ancestors who watch over and protect the island.

500–1450

